workers who were ‘kept busy creating not only delights for the emperor but also gifts for family members, favoured courtiers and rival rulers’.

At their peak, Akbar’s taswir khanas would have 145 Hindu painters and 115 Muslim painters, far more than the next great collector of artists, Jahangir, who would only have 43 and 41 respectively. With his usual unbridled enthusiasm Akbar would indiscriminately promote a large variety of artists as opposed to the smaller number of ‘master artists’ preferred by his heirs. The wages of artists were comparable to that of soldiers, and they could be rewarded extravagantly for outstanding work, such as with grants of villages or even elephants. Artists did not remain in the studios but accompanied Akbar wherever he went, to battlefields, pilgrimages, on hunts, and extended campaigns. The art being produced at Akbar’s ateliers now was different from the earlier large-scale projects—the *Hamzanama*, for example. Now the works of art were usually only a few inches across, meant to be held in the hand, and scrutinized closely in their fine details, and were exceptional ‘masterpieces’, the work of a single master artist rather than a collaborative effort between several painters.

The *Anwar-i Suhayli*, painted at this time, was one of the first examples of this style in which overall directions were given by the Safavid artist Abd al-Samad but then individual artists, usually local in origin, such as Basawan and Miskin, carried out the actual work. These Hindustani artists brought an exuberance to their brushwork and a soaring imagination, especially in their paintings of animals, that seemed to visibly struggle to stay within the elegant framework of the Persian masters. Though Akbar admired his Safavid masters, he was particularly moved by the work of his Hindu painters, some of whom had come to court as spoils of war, as in the case of the booty from the campaign against Rani Durgavati. Lacking a formal education himself, he would have thrilled to see the raw, untethered talent of these artists, some from very humble backgrounds—palki-bearers, stonecutters, water carriers. ‘Judge the nobility of any one’s being and great lineage,’ wrote Akbar to his son Daniyal many years later, ‘from the essence of his merit, and not from the pedigree of his ancestors or greatness of the seed.’ Most tellingly, the names of these artists were written in red ink near the lower margin of the painting, silent testimony of the high regard Akbar had for his painters, remarkable and rare for his time. Even more intriguingly, three of the names are those of women—Nadira Banu, Sahifa Banu, and Ruqiya Banu. The presence of these female artists allows one to